

MIG-12

Migrant Interview: Inclusion and Xenophobia

Interviewee Profile

Interview code: MIG-12

Age: 43

Gender: Male

Country of origin: Afghanistan

Host country: Germany

Years in host country: 5

Occupation: Interpreter

Interview

Q1. Can you tell me about your journey and what brought you to your host country?

A: I fled Afghanistan five years ago because of direct threats against my life, which arose from my having worked with international organisations, work that marked me and my family as targets when the security situation deteriorated. When things collapsed, staying would have meant almost certain death for me and grave danger for my wife and children, so we had no real choice but to leave everything behind. Germany ultimately accepted us as refugees, offering the safety we so desperately needed. Leaving my homeland, the country where generations of my family had lived, worked, and were buried, was the most heartbreaking decision I have ever had to make, a wound that has not closed, but it was the only way to keep my family alive.

Q2. What does 'inclusion' mean to you personally?

A: Inclusion means being able to use my skills, my education, and my professional experience to contribute to this society, rather than being reduced to nothing more than a refugee, a number in a system, defined solely by my having fled. It shows itself when my former professional life and accomplishments are acknowledged and given some weight, and when my children are treated as genuine equals in school, with the same opportunities as their German classmates. Belonging, for me, means rebuilding a dignified life in which we are valued members of German society, contributing and participating, rather than remaining permanently on the outside as objects of charity or, worse, of suspicion, always marked as people who do not truly belong.

Q3. Have you experienced xenophobia or discrimination? Can you describe it?

A: Yes, we have faced xenophobia, particularly as visibly Muslim refugees, a combination that seems to attract particular hostility. There is a persistent suspicion and occasional open hostility, which has been worsened considerably by negative political rhetoric specifically targeting Afghan refugees in public debate. My wife, who wears a headscarf and is therefore immediately identifiable, has faced particular hostility, comments and stares and cold treatment, which pains me deeply because I could not always protect her from it. It is a bitter and painful irony that we fled persecution and violence in our homeland only to encounter prejudice and rejection in the very place that was supposed to be our refuge.

and our new beginning.

Q4. What have been the biggest challenges in adapting to your new country?

A: The greatest challenges were the deep trauma of everything we had escaped, which does not simply vanish upon arriving somewhere safe, combined with the lengthy and stressful asylum process and the difficulty of learning German as an adult while simultaneously trying to support a family. Getting my foreign qualifications and professional experience recognised proved nearly impossible, so I effectively had to rebuild my entire career from scratch, starting far below where I had been. And the prolonged uncertainty during the asylum period itself, the not knowing whether we would be allowed to stay or forced to return to danger, was psychologically exhausting for all of us and cast a long shadow over those first years of supposed safety.

Q5. How would you describe your experience in the workplace or professional environment?

A: I now work as an interpreter, helping other Afghan and Farsi-speaking refugees to navigate the systems and situations they encounter, which is deeply meaningful work that turns my own painful experience into something genuinely useful for others. My colleagues in this field understand the challenges of migration and displacement, often intimately, so the working environment is supportive and I do not have to constantly explain myself. Using my language skills and my understanding of both cultures to help others find their way through the bewildering processes I once struggled with myself gives me a real sense of purpose and, importantly, a renewed sense of professional dignity that the loss of my former career had badly shaken.

Q6. How do you balance maintaining your cultural identity with integrating into the host society?

A: I preserve my Afghan identity through our language, our cuisine, our rich tradition of poetry, and our Islamic faith, actively teaching my children about the depth and beauty of their heritage so that it is not lost to them in exile. Simultaneously, I have wholeheartedly embraced German values and the German language, striving to integrate as fully as I can rather than remaining apart. I want my children to grow up as proud Afghans and as successful, well-integrated Germans at the same time, carrying both cultures forward with confidence and without any sense of shame or division. I believe firmly that these two identities can coexist and enrich one another, and I try to model that for them.

Q7. How do you feel the media portrays migrants from your background?

A: German media often portrays Afghan refugees primarily through the lens of crime or as a security concern, especially in the wake of isolated incidents that receive enormous and disproportionate coverage. This kind of framing unfairly stigmatises all of us, so that the actions of a very few come to define how the many are seen and treated. The great majority of Afghans here, who are working, studying, raising families, and contributing peacefully to German society, are rarely shown or acknowledged in the media at all. This persistent imbalance in coverage directly fuels the prejudice and suspicion that my family and I encounter in our everyday lives, shaping perceptions before any real contact occurs.

Q8. Have integration programs or community support been helpful in your experience?

A: The integration courses provided by Germany were genuinely helpful for learning the language and for understanding German civic values and how the society functions, and I am grateful for them and

for the investment they represent. However, the overall process was slow, and the support available for dealing with trauma and for professional re-qualification, for helping people rebuild the careers they had before, was clearly insufficient to the need. Germany offers more support than a great many other countries, which I do not take for granted, but the system can nonetheless feel impersonal and heavily bureaucratic, tending to overlook refugees' individual skills, histories, and specific needs in favour of processing everyone through the same standardised channels.

Q9. How has the next generation (or younger migrants) adapted compared to you?

A: My children are adapting well, learning German quickly and making friends among their German peers, which brings me tremendous joy and relief after everything we went through to reach safety. I do worry about them gradually losing their Afghan identity as they immerse themselves in German life, so I work hard at home to keep our culture, language, and traditions alive and present for them. They represent hope to me above all, a generation that can grow up in safety and stability, free from the fear and danger that shadowed my own life and the childhood that the war and its aftermath effectively stole from them. Watching them flourish is what makes all the sacrifice worthwhile.

Q10. In your opinion, what would help reduce xenophobia in society?

A: To reduce xenophobia, Germans need accurate and honest information about why Afghans are forced to flee their country and about the real contributions that refugees make once they are given the chance, because so much hostility rests on misunderstanding both. Political leaders bear a particular responsibility to avoid inflammatory and scapegoating rhetoric, which does real damage to community relations for the sake of short-term advantage. And personal contact is transformative, as I have seen with my own eyes; when Germans get to know refugee families personally, as neighbours or through their children's friendships, abstract fear tends to dissolve into understanding and often into genuine warmth. Programmes that deliberately bring locals and refugees together in shared activities are especially powerful for building these bridges.

Q11. What are your hopes and dreams for the future?

A: I hope to have my professional qualifications properly recognised so that I might return to a career that matches my education and experience, rather than remaining permanently below the level I once occupied. I want above all to see my children flourish and build successful lives and careers here, achieving the security and opportunity that I could not guarantee them in Afghanistan. And, though I hardly dare to voice it, I dream of an Afghanistan at peace, though I fear in my heart that I may never be able to return safely to the homeland that I still love deeply despite everything, and that my children may know it only through my stories and memories.

Q12. What advice would you give to new migrants arriving in your host country?

A: My advice to fellow refugees is to embrace learning the language as your absolute top priority from the very beginning, because it unlocks everything else, work, dignity, friendship, and the ability to advocate for yourself and your family. Be patient through the difficult, slow, and often demoralising asylum process, because it does eventually end. Actively seek out both your own community, for understanding and support, and open-minded locals, for connection and integration. Work to preserve your heritage while genuinely adapting to your new home, because you can and should do both. And,

hardest of all, try to transform your pain and loss into strength, above all for the sake of your children and their future.